Little’s instructions for dew

The drops that did not fall.

Name _____ Date _____



Before sunrise, Little Wonderer found tiny drops on a leaf. A spider web beside it wore shining beads. “Did I miss the rain?” Little asked. The path was dry. Big Wonderer knelt beside the leaf. “Let’s follow the clues back through the night.”



The night had been clear and calm. The leaf gave off heat to the open sky. It cooled and could get colder than the air around it. Little began a list of nature’s instructions: “1. Cool the leaf.” Nothing had fallen from the sky.



Air holds water vapor, water in a gas form we cannot see. Air touching the cool leaf cooled too. At the dew point, it was cool enough that it could not keep all its water invisible. Little added: “2. Wait for the air to touch it.”

water vapor	water in a gas form that we cannot see
dew point	the temperature where cooling air becomes cool enough for water vapor to condense
condense	change from a gas into liquid drops
evaporate	change from liquid water into water vapor
command	a sentence that tells what to do, such as “Cool the leaf.”

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Tiny drops formed right on the leaf. Water vapor had begun to condense: it changed from a gas into liquid water. That water was dew. The cool spider web held beads too. “3. Look for tiny drops,” Little wrote. “They formed here. They did not fall like rain!”



Little checked the order: cool the leaf, let air touch it, then notice dew. “My commands are like a little program,” Little said. “But nature does not read my notebook!” Big smiled. The instructions helped Little explain the changes, one step at a time.



Sunrise warmed the leaf. The beads grew smaller as water began to evaporate: it changed from liquid back into invisible vapor. Little added one last command: “4. Warm the leaf.” The water was not gone forever. It had returned to the air. What would the next night bring?

1. What two clues made Little wonder if the drops came from rain?
2. Why did Little put “Cool the leaf” before “Look for tiny drops”?
3. What happened to the water when sunrise warmed the leaf?

Your turn

Write one command sentence for the leaf’s story. Tell what to do.

Example: First cool the leaf, then wait for tiny drops.